

CASE STUDY

The shelves were empty. The warehouse was full.

They asked us to build a better demand-forecasting model. The real problem: a smarter forecast still died in a two-day manual gap. Nobody owned the decision — and the system had quietly outgrown its design

Real Problem

“Build us a better demand-forecasting model. Ours keeps getting it wrong.”

Scope

A better forecast still died in a twoday manual gap. The issue wasn’t prediction — it was that nobody owned the decision.

01. The Situation

A fast-moving consumer goods distributor serving independent retailers and supermarket chains across Gauteng and the Western Cape faced a paradox leadership struggled to explain: stockouts and overstock at the same time. High-demand SKUs ran dry in stores while the distribution centre sat on months of slow-moving inventory. This was not a small operation — 2,400+ SKUs moving daily across 340 retail accounts. At that scale, Excel models, weekly sales reports, and buying-manager intuition were overwhelmed. Nobody was wrong; the system was. It had been built for a business a quarter of the size and never redesigned as the company grew.

02. What We Found

Our diagnostic surfaced three compounding issues.

- 1. **Forecasting on four-week averages.** It missed seasonal spikes, promotional lifts, and the demand differences between Gauteng and the Cape.
- 2. **Manual replenishment, with a two-day lag.** Between a low-stock trigger and a purchase order being raised. In a fast-moving category, two days is expensive.
- 3. **Slotting by arrival date, not turnover.** High-velocity products often sat in the least accessible locations, slowing every pick.

67%

of South Africa’s large enterprises had adopted GenAI by mid-2025 — most without a strategy. This client was about to commission the same forecasting model the market already had. We told them the model wasn’t the problem.

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03. What We Did

We didn’t start with a model. We started with the decision.

Predictive forecasting

We replaced four-week averages with demand-sensing models that account for seasonality, promotions, and the Gauteng–Cape demand gap. Real-time signals now drive replenishment, not stale averages.

A conversational interface

A generative AI layer let buying managers ask, in plain language, and get ranked, confidence-scored answers. The AI surfaces; they decide.

Smarter slotting

Velocity analysis moved the top 20% of SKUs by turnover into primary pick locations—lifting fulfilment speed immediately.

04. How We Rolled It Out

We ran an eight-week data integration and cleansing phase before training anything — the most critical and most underestimated step. We normalised 36 months of historical transactions and fixed the ERP’s Data Quality issues first. We trained the models on clean data and validated them against six months of historical outcomes before going live. We put the buying managers inside that validation, so trust was built before the system ever touched their daily workflow. Within three months of go-live, the team was making fewer decisions — but better ones.

05. What an Engagement Like This Delivers

Once the decision had an owner and clean signals to act on, the gains followed — fewer stockouts, leaner inventory, faster fulfilment.

40%

Fewer stockouts

Real-time signals replace rolling averages.

28%

Less working capital tied up

Slow-moving overstock freed from the warehouse.

30%

Faster order fulfilment

Tighter replenishment cycles plus AI-led slotting.

The win wasn’t a better forecast.It was a decision that finally had an owner.

Bring us the problem

No proposal until we understand the problem.